

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

FASTER, SMOOTHER, HAPPIER
A truck driver shows an e-challan generated through the Suvidha portal at Petrapole border crossing, West Bengal

WEST BENGAL

A PORTAL TO BETTER TRADE

project in July 2022.

Before Suvidha came, exporters faced endless delays, with trucks languishing at borders for 40 to 70 days due to fiendish bottlenecks. Cross-border trade at Petrapole was especially nightmarish. Exporters would often run up Rs 1 lakh in detention costs, that too for consignments that ran the risk of spoilage. Exorbitant sums had to be paid to touts and middlemen to skip the queue.

The portal has slashed waiting time to just one-two days. In a transparent process, exporters can book slots for their trucks through the portal by paying a fee ranging from Rs 3,000 to Rs 15,000, which include platform charges for the government and fees levied by customs and LPAI. Trucks now arrive at a designated time, bypassing the need for extended detention. "The Suvidha portal has removed hassles, enabling even women drivers to undertake journeys," says Kamlesh Saini, manager of the Petrapole Land Port. Sunil Kumar, a trucker from Punjab, notes, "I arrive at Petrapole a day before my slot, park in the LPAI warehouse and cross the border by evening the next day."

The Suvidha portal is built on cutting-edge technology. Automatic Number Plate Recognition cameras scan vehicle numbers and retrieve details from the Vahan database. The Sarathi database provides driver details, reducing the need for manual checks. Exporters, customs officials and drivers, all receive real-time notifications about truck movements with transparency. The average export release time at Petrapole was reduced from 60 hours in 2022 to just 14 hours in 2023, says a report by the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs. "Our costs have reduced significantly and everything is systematic. If we face issues, a dedicated team resolves them promptly," says Pradip Dey, secretary of the Export Import Association of Bangaon.

BIZ IS THE BUZZ

- **Using cutting-edge tech, Bengal's efficient Suvidha portal has transformed cross-border trade at Petrapole and other land borders with Bangladesh**
- **A streamlined process has cut cost per transaction from Rs 70,000 to Rs 3,000-15,000; waiting time reduced from 40-70 days to 1-2 days**
- **The state government has earned around Rs 600 crore in tax revenue**

The success of Suvidha resulted from the collaboration between two IPS officers from the 1989 batch—Rajeev Kumar, West Bengal's additional chief secretary of IT, and LPAI chairman Aditya Mishra. They had to overcome many challenges—including resistance from touts and even an attack on Saini. Kumar deputed Sukesh Kumar Jain, the incumbent inspector general of police, traffic, as project head. Multiple meetings took place between all stakeholders, including Bangladeshi officials. "The primary focus was to maximise exports and protect exporters from ill practices. In this, we have been successful," Jain tells INDIA TODAY.

The success of Suvidha has inspired similar initiatives, like the LPAI's Land Port Management System (LMPS) in Agartala, Tripura. "We have launched LMPS in Tripura and will do the same with other land ports," says Mishra. The LPAI manages 15 ICPs in the country currently.

The Bengal government has extended the Suvidha model to passenger movement. The newly launched Yatri Suvidha portal at Petrapole allows travellers to book slots for immigration interviews, eliminating long queues. Suvidha won gold at the 26th National Awards for eGovernance 2023. It has been lauded by the World Bank for its transformative impact on cross-border trade. The portal stands as a model of progress, demonstrating how technology, with a little help from friends, can revolutionise trade. ■